

COVID-19 AND GROUP-MAKING IN R/TRAVEL: SHIFT IN NORMS
THROUGH EXPRESSION AND IDENTITY MARKERS (2018-2022)

Alan Benedict Joseph
15562611

Workgroup Number: 2
19 December 2025

Digital Research Seminar
Seminar Research Report

Integrity Statement

I affirm that this assignment was written by me, in accordance with
the rules and regulations governing fraud and plagiarism for UvA students.

Signed by:
Alan Benedict Joseph

Introduction

Reddit as a platform is known for social news aggregation, web content rating and discussion amongst users called redditors relating to a variety of topics. The subreddit r/Travel according to its introduction is a “community about exploring the world.” Created in 2008, this subreddit currently has 1.9 million “travellers” and 20,000 “just chilling” redditors. The subreddit has diacritical features which according to Barth are “overt signals or signs that people in a community exhibit to show identity and reflect basic value orientations.” (Barth 1969) This can be found in its wiki page which has specific instructions and rules that must be followed in the group to ask questions and advice related to travel (“R/Travel FAQ: Your Travel Questions, Answered,” n.d.) which differentiates it from other subreddits.

Different authors have used r/travel to discuss various topics. Hao et. al specifically discussed the pandemic related discourses in r/travel from the perspective of disaster risk reduction and management by using text analytics, emotion detection and timeline comparison methods (Hao et al. 2024). Park et. al. used the same subreddit to study the aspect of “mental time travel” by analysing the manifestation of past and future oriented temporal frames and how it influenced the users during periods of travel disruption like the pandemic by using topic modelling and LIWC software for analysing the association of temporal and sentiment dimensions in the subreddit. (Park et al. 2025) Oliveira analysed r/travel to understand the cultural identity of the tourist and its construction in the subreddit from the context of posting practices of users which privileges elements like information, experience and representations of the place over representation of individualized elements like selfies by using text mining and image classification. (Oliveira 2022)

This paper will try to address the aspect of community and group formation in the Reddit platform by examining r/travel using the ideas that are discussed by Baym in her paper “The Emergence of On-Line Community.” According to Baym, group making in a group like a subreddit is manifested through the discourse in the group, which through different dimensions like forms of expression codify group specific meanings and negotiates group specific identities dependent on specific markers and temporal structure of the group which creates norms that influences how the group is made, maintained or reoriented. These norms are changeable and also highly influenced by external contexts. (Baym 1998) This paper is trying to show how in an online community like r/travel, the dimension of an external context like COVID-19 pandemic forced a shift in norms by showing how it affected other dimensions

of an online community like forms of expression and identity markers and categorising words into these two dimensions on the basis of diacritical features of r/travel.

This will be accomplished by asking the research question: How did the COVID-19 pandemic reconfigure r/travel by shifting the subreddit's norms through dimensions of external context, forms of expression and identity, by showing its changes over a time using topic modelling and difference in concordance patterns between a pre-COVID corpus (Dec 2018–Jan 2020) and a COVID-period corpus (Nov 2020–Jan 2022)?

Methodology

To show the shift in the subreddit's norms, data about r/travel which includes its submissions and comments were downloaded from a reddit archive called the eye. The dataset was processed to create sample files for two time periods: November 2018 to January 2020 (non-COVID sample) and November 2020 to January 2022 (COVID sample). The docbin files created from them became the basis for topic modelling which was done by converting them into a matrix market corpus and a LDA (Latent Dirichlet Allocation) dictionary and yielded a document topic matrix. Topic modelling was applied to trace semantic patterns in the corpus by searching for patterns in the use of words which helped to engage in distant reading. (Van De Ven and Van Nuenen 2022) Visualization tools in web browser were used to explore and evaluate multiple models with pyLDavis created using different k (number of topic) values (10, 25, 50 and 75). The topics in topic modelling are defined as “distribution lists of word probabilities based on co-occurrences of words in the same documents.” (Walter et al. 2022)

The topics were created using the COVID sample as it also showed baseline topics that were already prevalent in r/travel before an external context like COVID caused changes in the group as evidenced by the topics generated by the models. The k50 model was chosen as it gave a clearly defined 4 topics related to the pandemic and the remaining 46 topics had dimensions that would be found in a non-COVID sample. A visualization of the document topic matrix was also created by selecting 6 models (3 models showing evidence of pandemic discourse and 3 models showing the baseline non pandemic discourse) which showed how COVID influenced the topics over the time period. Each topic gave 30 relevant terms for each topic out of which topics 9, 14 and 22 showed the terms most associated with the pandemic. Topics 21, 23 and 36 were chosen as these topics best summarized the diacritical features that

defined r/travel as a community. The relevance metric was adjusted to 0.4 which gave the best results and better coherence with minimum overlap of the topic and its words. It was on the basis of these words' that concordances were run.

The docbin and frequency distribution files (with named entities) were together used to process concordances with a window size of 30 (after multiple attempts) and sample size of 10 was found to give coherent results in both pre-COVID and COVID samples. Looking at keywords in context was essential for understanding discourse by uncovering evidence for various preferences which can change due to external contexts and to prevent incorrect assumptions about the content of the corpus. (Baker 2010) 3 words were chosen to run concordance from the topic models on the basis of Baym's idea of how the dimension of external context influenced the other dimension of expression and identity markers. The 3 words selected were corresponding to and clearly connected with the diacritical features of r/travel on the basis of the above-mentioned dimensions in both COVID and non-COVID samples. This would show that a change had occurred in the norms of r/travel about how the talk about the process of travelling and the changes to the markers of the identity of the traveller had shifted.

Findings

Topic_9	Words related to COVID-19 Procedures
Topic_14	Words describing the Pandemic and hope for its end
Topic_22	Specific words related to COVID-19 and Travel in r/travel

Table 1: Topic Models showing external context of COVID

Topic_21	Words related to Flights
Topic_23	Words describing planning the process of planning a trip
Topic_36	Words related to feelings experienced while Travelling

Table 2: Topic Models showing baseline topics already prevalent

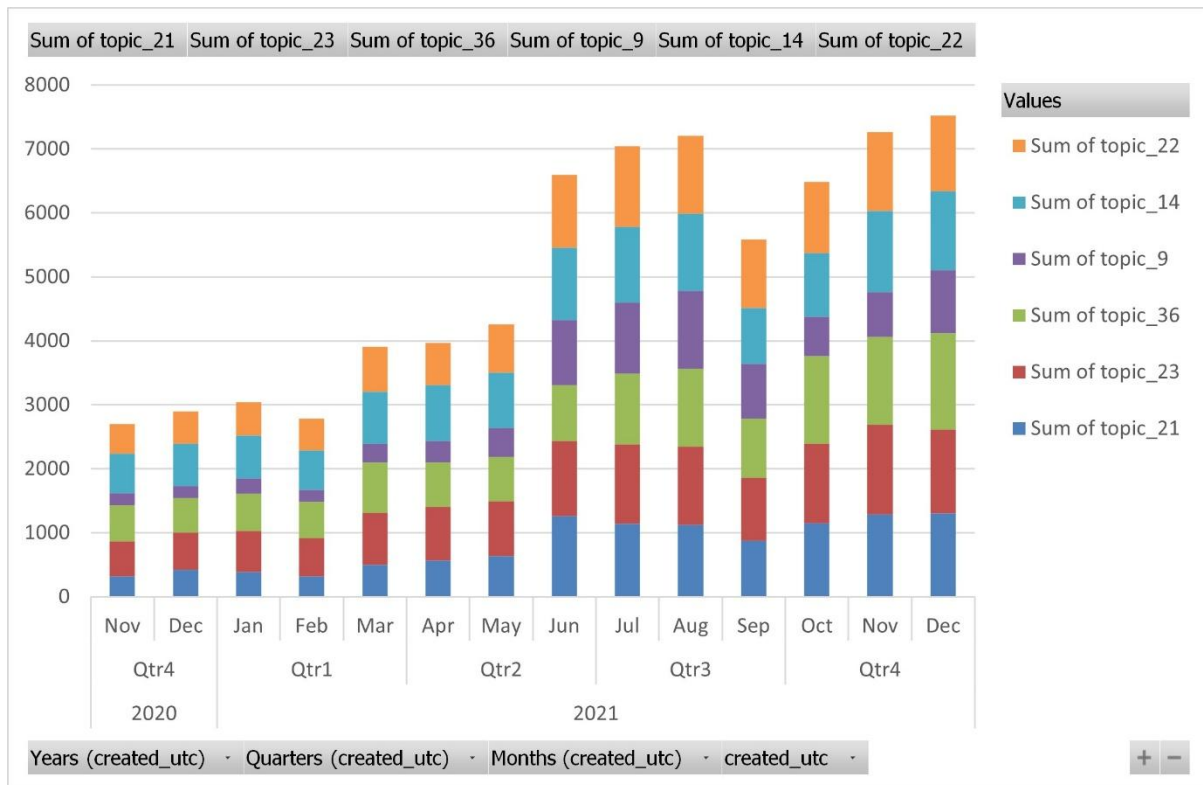


Fig 1: Visualization of Topics 2020-2022

A distant reading of the graph shows, the topic models 21, 23 and 36 correspond to the topics that were already prevalent in the subreddit undergoes ups and downs in correspondence with topic models 9, 14 and 22 which are topics showing the influence of external factor of COVID. Topic 21 which deals with flights is not much discussed until June 2021. Same is the case for topics 23 (planning a trip), 36 (feelings experienced while travelling) and 9 (COVID procedures). It is interesting to note that topics 14 (hope for the pandemic to end) and 22 (connecting r/travel vocabulary with COVID-19) were the topics that were discussed consistently during all the quarters. This would indicate that the decrease in discussion of all topics seen in fourth quarter of 2020 and first quarter of 2021 was caused due to the external factor of COVID which brought down the discussion about flights, planning of trips and how people felt while they travelled which are diacritical features in the subreddit.

As travel restrictions were reduced and vaccines were introduced (Whitmore 2021), the discussions 21, 23 and 36 increased. A substantial increase can be seen in topic 9 which dealt with COVID procedures while travelling. It is only when these procedures were followed to the dot that people were allowed to travel. This also increased hope in the subreddit that the pandemic is about to end (shown by spike in topic 14). But in September 2021, a drop in discussion of all topic model can be seen as it was during this time that the highly contagious

delta variant was spreading. (UN News 2021) But it immediately picks up by October 2021. The last quarter of 2021 sees the highest increase for all topics, which shows that the impact of COVID-19 on travelling was reducing as more people were getting vaccinated, following procedures and more countries were opening up to tourists.

The distant reading helped understand the pattern changes caused by the external context of COVID-19. A close reading of the discourses of these patterns was done by running concordance on words that are diacritical features of r/travel based on two dimensions: forms of expression i.e. cancel|VERB and close|VERB and forms of identity markers i.e. vaccinate|VERB. These words are considered as diacritical features as these are clear signs that mark help to mark their identity as a traveller following the basic value orientation of the subreddit influenced by the discourse in the subreddit.

Cancel and close are expressions “that enable users to communicate social information and to create and codify group-specific meanings” (Baym 1998) Questions asked with close and cancel effect the planning of the whole trip and even cause changes in the whole itinerary mid trip. The social information communicated creates a specific meaning that changes depending on the external context of the subreddit. Vaccinate is an identity marker which unlike forms of expression is bound to change with both time and context. Vaccinate is an identity which decides if the trip is even possible.

In the case of cancel|VERB it was seen in the concordances that it changed from a word that meant only small changes to the travel plan like “flight may be cancelled or hotels will let you cancel” or “can cancel for free” or “your flight is cancelled.” During COVID, this changed to “had to cancel because of the pandemic”, or “reservation had to be cancelled because of the pandemic” or “honeymoon to get cancelled.” But it is interesting to note that despite cancelling, the pandemic gave these people new questions to ask like when one person got credit for cancellation from the airline which he wants to use to plan a new trip or how the person used the pandemic as a reason to get refund for the reservation or how the lifting of restrictions gives hope that the couple can enjoy their honeymoon in their third attempt.

In the case of close|VERB, it can be seen that it changed from a word where changes have to be made mid travel like “how shops are closed in June” or places closing due to weather factors” or “arts museum is permanently closed.” During COVID, it changed the whole plan and even the possibility of planning a trip itself as seen in instances like “US-Mexico land

border is closed” or “Russia was still closed off” or “cafes and restaurants are closed in France.” The air of uncertainty and the strict restrictions made it almost impossible to plan the trip itself.

In the case of *vaccinate*|VERB, in normal instances, this identity marker was not that important. Only in some instances like travelling to some countries vaccination was needed and was a personal preference. Some instance like “was vaccinated and got typhoid in India” or “get vaccinated for encephalitis” or “got vaccinated before going to Asia.” Even if not vaccinated, the person could still travel. But in the external context of COVID, things changed completely as seen by “are you vaccinated” or “without being vaccinated, you have to quarantine” or “we are fully vaccinated.” Hence these two forms of expression and one identity marker show that an external context like COVID influenced the meanings and how the words are used. The temporal frame also show that in the last quarter of 2021, these discussions started to change affecting the identity and not the forms of expression as the stress on *vaccinate* was reduced but *cancel* and *close* were still relevant.

Conclusion

Baym discusses how the external context of soap operas can influence group purposes (Baym 1998). Here the external context of COVID completely changed the purpose of the group: from asking questions about travelling to giving importance to promoting restraint and following the rules more strictly as seen from the topic modelling. The concordances showed the changes in communication over time from the context of forms of expression and identity markers. The marker discussed for short period became a diacritical feature of the subreddit but over time lost this while the form of expressions still is a diacritical feature apart from the influence of the external context. From a methodological perspective it showed how combining topic modelling and concordance with dimension of external context, identity markers and forms of expression helps to map the discourse of a subreddit to trace the changes caused by these dimensions.

Bibliography

- Baker, Paul. 2010. *Sociolinguistics and Corpus Linguistics*. Edinburgh Sociolinguistics. Edinburgh university press.
- Baym, Nancy K. 1998. "The Emergence of On-Line Community." In *Cybersociety 2.0: Revisiting Computer-Mediated Communication and Community*, by Steven Jones. SAGE Publications, Inc. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781452243689.n2>.
- Hao, Fei, Eunhye (Olivia) Park, and Kaye Chon. 2024. "Social Media and Disaster Risk Reduction and Management: How Have Reddit Travel Communities Experienced the COVID-19 Pandemic?" *Journal of Hospitality & Tourism Research* 48 (1): 58–83. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10963480221081115>.
- Oliveira, Rafael Almeida De. 2022. *No Selfies, Please: An Analysis of Travel Texts and Images from Reddit*.
- (Olivia) Park, Eunhye, Woohyuk Kim, and Sung-Bum Kim. 2025. "Mental Time Travel in Online Travel Communities: The Application of Past and Future Time Orientations." *Journal of Hospitality & Tourism Research* 49 (1): 160–73. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10963480231177846>.
- "R/Travel FAQ: Your Travel Questions, Answered." n.d. Accessed December 17, 2025. https://www.reddit.com/r/travel/wiki/index/?share_id=c0Y1ciFwEIItaCR7cXfWd&utm_content=1&utm_medium=ios_app&utm_name=ioscss&utm_source=share&utm_term=1.
- Van De Ven, Inge, and Tom Van Nuenen. 2022. "Digital Hermeneutics: Scaled Readings of Online Depression Discourses." *Medical Humanities* 48 (3): 335–46. <https://doi.org/10.1136/medhum-2020-012104>.
- Walter, Dror, Yotam Ophir, Ayse D. Lokmanoglu, and Meredith L. Pruden. 2022. "Vaccine Discourse in White Nationalist Online Communication: A Mixed-Methods Computational Approach." *Social Science & Medicine* 298 (April): 114859. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.socscimed.2022.114859>.